

Dirassat & Abhath
The Arabic Journal of Human
and Social Sciences



مجلة دراسات وأبحاث
المجلة العربية في العلوم الإنسانية
والاجتماعية

EISSN: 2253-0363
ISSN : 1112-9751

**Interaction with Jazz Music
in the Poetry Collection *The Jazz Child* by Mohammed Dib**
التفاعل مع موسيقى الجاز في ديوان "الطفل الجاز" لمحمد ديب

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تاريخ القبول : 2025/12/21

تاريخ الاستلام: 2025/07/17

Abstract:

This research explores the artistic and aesthetic interaction with jazz music in Mohammed Dib's poetry collection, "The Jazz Child", viewing it as a modernist poetic experiment that embraces the African-rooted American musical rhythm and employs it as a medium for expression and culture.

The collection reflects an artistic awareness of jazz techniques (such as improvisation, repetition, and rhythmic fragmentation), utilizing them within a poetic text that is based on the aesthetic breaking of traditions and an openness to representations of the Other. Dib also evokes jazz as a space for freedom and liberation, poetically reconfiguring it within an existential contemplative horizon. This makes the child a symbol of a new sensibility, and jazz a language of rebellion, hybridity, and multiculturalism.

This interaction represents one aspect of post-colonial poetic experimentation, where the African American voice meets the Algerian voice in a text that blends the local with the universal.

Keywords: Mohammed Dib – The Jazz Child – Jazz Music – Musical Intertextuality – Cultural Hybridity.

الملخص

يتناول هذا البحث التفاعل الفني والجمالي مع موسيقى الجاز في ديوان "الطفل الجاز" لمحمد ديب، باعتباره تجربة شعرية حدائية تنفتح على الإيقاع الموسيقي الأمريكي ذي الجذور الإفريقية، وتوظفه كوسيط تعبيرية وثقافي. يعكس الديوان وعياً فنياً بتقنيات الجاز (مثل الارتجال، التكرار، التقطيع الإيقاعي)، ويوظفها داخل نص شعري يقوم على الكسر الجمالي للتقاليد، والانفتاح على تمثيلات الآخر. كما يستحضر ديب الجاز كفضاء للحرية والتحرر، ويعيد تشكيله شعرياً ضمن أفق تأملي وجودي، يجعل من الطفل رمزاً للحساسية الجديدة، ومن الجاز لغة للتمرد والهجنة والتعدد الثقافي. يشكل هذا التفاعل أحد أوجه التجريب الشعري ما بعد الكولونيالي، حيث يلتقي الصوت الإفريقي الأمريكي بالصوت الجزائري في نص يزواج بين المحلي والكوني.

الكلمات المفتاحية: محمد ديب – الطفل الجاز – موسيقى الجاز – التناص الموسيقي – الهجنة الثقافية.

1. INTRODUCTION

Mohammed Dib (1920–2003) is considered one of the most prominent Algerian writers who ventured into poetry alongside the novel and theater. He first gained recognition for his famous trilogy (The Big House, The Fire, The Dawn) which documented Algerian society during the French colonial era. However, his creative journey underwent profound transformations in both style and subject matter starting in the 1960s, when he chose voluntary exile in France and later in the United States, specifically California. During this period, a more complex intellectual and aesthetic experience

emerged, which Dib expressed through new literary forms, including poetry. One of the most significant examples of this phase is his collection *The Jazz Child* (1998).

Dib adopts jazz—as an African-American musical form that originated in a context of oppression and marginalization—as a central element to reshape his poetic voice and to forge a new relationship between the self, language, and the world (Hall, 1992, p. 222). In this collection, jazz does not appear merely as a decorative element or musical backdrop; rather, it forms a structural foundation upon which the entire poetic experience is built, whether in terms of rhythm and form or in terms of symbols and meanings (Genette, 1982, p. 5). The title

itself, *The Jazz Child* (L'Enfant-Jazz), encapsulates the intersection of childhood—as a space of innocence and openness—with jazz as music of marginality and rebellion (Kristeva, 1980, p. 45).

From this perspective, the article raises the following question:

How does Mohammed Dib engage with jazz music in his collection *The Jazz Child*, and what aesthetic and cultural dimensions does this interaction acquire within the poetic context?

To answer this question, we will adopt an aesthetic and cultural approach based on textual analysis and guided by concepts drawn from cultural intertextuality (interculturalité), sound aesthetics, and the theory of hybridity (hybridité) as articulated by postcolonial criticism. The collection *The Jazz Child* will be explored through three main axes:

1. Jazz as a rhythmic and poetic structure
2. Jazz as a cultural symbol of hybridity and cosmopolitan belonging
3. Jazz as a representation of the poetic self between childhood and rebellion

We begin our analysis following the structure of the above axes, starting with the first poem in the collection *The Jazz Child*, titled "The Tree."

First Axis: Jazz as a Rhythmic and Poetic Structure

The Tree

The tree was waiting,
Then darkness fell.
It remained there,
And the child was gazing at it.
He said: Night has come,
And having said that, he went back inside.
We had dinner. We stayed up late.
But the tree? the child said.
The child wondered
Under the lamp's light.
The child—the one
The tree came
To close his eyes.

2. Referential Level – Symbolic :

The element of the tree in the poem carries multilayered symbolic meanings:

A symbol of waiting nature, of fatherhood or of protection, as it waits silently without moving.

In Mohammed Dib's cosmic context—where he reinterprets the everyday and the mythical—the tree represents a maternal or universal figure, awaiting return or recognition.

The child represents innocence, but also the first awareness of time and destiny, as is the case throughout the rest of the collection. (Ducrot & Todorov, 1972, p. 413)

3. Intentionality and Speech Acts:

The poem unfolds within a quasi-narrative structure that appears simple on the surface, yet it conceals a deeply meaningful internal speech act. For example, the phrase "He said: Night has come" functions as a declarative statement, corresponding to what is known in speech act theory as an assertive function, intended to justify the subsequent action (i.e., returning indoors) (Searle, 1969, p. 38). However, this act is countered by the child's question: "And the tree?"—a question that opens both an existential and childlike horizon, revealing a profound awareness of other beings: Should they be left alone in the dark? Where do they belong?

These questions bring us back to what might be called an inner childlike philosophy which forms one of the pillars of Mohammed Dib's poetic vision, where childhood is not merely a stage of life, but an epistemological and contemplative tool that internalizes the anxieties of the world. (Abou Zayd, 1990, p. 85)

4. Literary and Cultural References:

The poem draws inspiration in its form from the techniques of the French prose poem, including a simple style, sequential semantic structure, and the absence of metrical musicality (Richard, 1955, p. 95).

We can also clearly hear echoes of the French existentialist style (as seen in Sartre and Camus), where isolation, darkness, and waiting together form a structure of childlike-cosmic anxiety (Camus, 1942, p. 118).

Within the broader references of *The Jazz Child* collection, the poem can be read as an existential haiku, blending nature, awareness, and darkness in a metaphysical experience wrapped in poetic simplicity (Bashō, 1986, p. 29).

5. Internal Intertextuality within the Collection:

In this poem, the “tree” is not depicted as a passing element of nature, but is invoked as a symbol of the stranger, the other, or exile—that which is always left outside the warmth of human connection, on the margins (Genette, 1982, p. 7). This symbolic function gives the poetic image an interpretive depth that transcends the local and gestures toward the universal.

As for the “child”, a recurring figure throughout *The Jazz Child*, he is not merely a textual protagonist, but rather a marveling eye, a revealing self that engages in open questioning beyond pre-established meaning (Kristeva, 1980, p. 45).

Thus, the poem *L’Arbre* stands as a poetic model for constructing a universal poem from local and childlike details, where apparent simplicity turns into symbolic and emotional depth. Through repetition, quiet rhythm, and condensed structure, Mohammed Dib draws us into the core of a childlike consciousness of existence, which forms the essence of what could be called “a cosmic poetics born from the margins” (Hall, 1992, p. 222).

Second Axis: Jazz as a Cultural Symbol of Hybridity and Cosmopolitan Belonging The Blind Man

Seen by everyone, he was there
Feeling his way without seeing a thing.
It was him, the blind man.
And if he opened his eyes?
If he were to open his eyes again
Amid all these unknown things?
Coming without stumbling, coming
Toward all those who would see that?
He stepped forward and said: Thank you
night.
No one saw anyone arrive.

1. Referential Level

The “blind man” in this poem is not to be understood merely as a condition of visual impairment; rather, he emerges as a symbol of the exiled self within a mysterious and incomprehensible world. This figure can be read as the poet-child, or the postcolonial subject navigating a reality to which he does not belong and for which he lacks the keys of interpretation (Hall, 1992, p. 222).

As for the “night,” it is not simply a narrative moment in time, but a dense symbolic reference—in both African and Arab cultures—laden with meanings of uncertainty, estrangement, and disconnection, granting the textual space an open cultural dimension rich with symbolism and absence (Kristeva, 1980, p. 60).

In contrast, the recurring phrase “unknown things” evokes a postmodern horizon, where meaning collapses, references fragment, and the world is transformed into a web of open-ended signs and existential alienation (Genette, 1982, p. 34).

2. Intentionality and Speech Acts:

The utterance “*Merci, nuit*” (Thank you night) is a semantically rich speech act expressing a symbolic surrender or reconciliation—with darkness? With hybridity? With the world?

The question “*Et s’il ouvrait les yeux?*” (And if he opened his eyes?) is an exploratory act, inviting the emergence of a new vision of the world (Searle, 1969, p. 38).

But this speech act is soon countered by a follow-up question: “*And the tree?*”—which brings us back to an existential-childlike dimension, where childhood is not satisfied with direct answers but raises the big questions about who is left in the dark, and about the relationship between the inside and the outside (Abou Zayd, 1990, p. 85).

3. Cultural References and Hybridity:

Jazz as a background layer of the text: The poem’s free rhythm and interpretive improvisation resemble the structure of jazz. The poem speaks of awareness within darkness—a familiar image in exilic

literature, and one echoed in jazz as an expression of Black consciousness.

The form of the poem refers to the French prose poem (*poème en prose*): inner rhythm, free linguistic structure, lack of meter, and the presence of a contemplative voice (Ducrot & Todorov, 1972, p. 413).

The poem also recalls the style of Japanese haiku in its compression of images and everyday scenes to evoke existential depth (Bashō, 1986, p. 29).

It is also imbued with an existential vision as seen in the works of Camus and Sartre: waiting, darkness, and silence (Camus, 1942, p. 118).

The hybrid identity is expressed through the self feeling its way among "unknown things"—just as jazz blends with languages and cultures.

4. Cosmopolitan Belonging:

The character of "the blind man" in the poem embodies a mysterious, undefined being, with no clear identity or affiliation. He is present—"vu de tous" (seen by all)—yet at the same time, he belongs to no one. This paradox reflects the condition of cosmopolitan existence, which transcends geographic and social belonging in favor of an open, symbolic affiliation (Hall, 1992, p. 226).

The phrase "No one saw anyone arrive" conveys a sense of existential solitude, removing the self from fixed categories and propelling it toward a mapless state, where one moves toward meaning without certainty, but guided by intuition. Within this horizon, Mohammed Dib presents his "blind" child as a symbolic hybrid self—one that sees in darkness, navigates the world without colliding, and aligns with the logic of jazz as an art of freedom, openness, and multiplicity (Kristeva, 1980, p. 70).

The poem, then, is not constructed around a fixed center, but unfolds within an open, cosmic space, where language, vision, and belonging are all fluid concepts in the making. This positions the text as a poetic declaration of the hybrid cosmopolitan human, who discovers the world not through the clarity of sight, but through an

internalization of darkness (Genette, 1982 p. 47).

The Magpie

He came out of the magpies

And began to record notes.

He began to record notes

And came out of the magpies.

He came out of the magpies

And began to record notes.

From the flute he will extract

To extract from the magpies

And record notes.

5. Form and Rhythm – A Jazz Feature:

The poem relies on the circular and fragmented repetition of the lines "Il tira des pies / Et se mit des notes", which precisely mirrors the riff technique in jazz music—the rhythmic repetition of musical phrases as a basis for improvisation (Fadl, 1998, p. 30). This structure gives the text a linguistic rhythm that closely resembles free-form music, echoing what Derek Walcott in postcolonial literature calls "rhythmical hybridity", where voices intertwine and languages overlap (Hall, 1992, p. 228).

5.1. Symbolic Significance:

The magpie (pies) in European culture is often a symbol of noise and repetition, known for its shrill cry and its fascination with stealing shiny objects. In this context the magpie becomes a metaphor for sonic chaos, multiplicity, and dialectical variation—the very qualities that define jazz as an urban, hybrid music born from diverse cultural and social struggles (Richard, 1955 p. 122).

As for the "notes", they carry a double meaning: both musical tones and written notations. The poetic self thus appears as a collector of marginal sounds, capable of transforming raw noise into melody, and chaos into linguistic beauty (Genette, 1982 p. 47).

5.2. Jazz as a Hybrid Discourse:

The poem embodies a poetic vision of jazz as a cultural and artistic act of hybridity—a process through which scattered sounds, different linguistic registers, and unfamiliar voices are reshaped into a new aesthetic experience. The poem does not merely

describe jazz; it enacts its structural and creative logic, by fusing dissonant elements and transforming them into a text that is open to multiplicity and transcendence (Hall, 1992, p. 231).

5.3. Intertextuality with the Jazz Discourse in the Collection

Throughout *L'Enfant-Jazz*, Mohammed Dib consistently draws on the idea of playing with words, where linguistic chaos is transformed into sonic beauty and poetic freedom. This structure appears in several poems, such as *L'Aveugle* and *L'Arbre*, where the poetic self searches for meaning amid symbolic darkness and semantic ambiguity—mirroring the style of jazz, which seeks harmony within improvisation (Genette, 1982, p. 47).

In the poem *Les Pies*, the creative act resembles an internal dialogue between the self and noise, between reason and music. The voice of the magpie—a loud and elusive bird—becomes a multi-layered melody where raw, unfiltered sounds are transformed into a poetic discourse that blends repetition, improvisation, and transformation (Hall, 1992, p. 233).

In this way, Mohammed Dib composes a true jazz-poem, built on four structural pillars inspired by jazz:

Improvisation

Repetition

Transformation of noise into beauty

Belonging to an infinite sonic space

This aesthetic shift turns the poem into a mirror of cosmopolitan belonging, where the individual learns to “extract” meaning from chaos—just as jazz, born from a colonial, racist, and fragmented reality, became a music of freedom, hybridity, and cultural plurality (Kristeva, 1980, p. 66).

Third Axis: Jazz as a Representation of the Poetic Self between Childhood and Rebellion

In the poem *Les Portes* (The Doors) Mohammed Dib employs poetic symbolism within a simple yet mysterious structure to reflect an inner architecture of anxiety refusal, and existential searching. The poem belongs to *L'Enfant-Jazz*, a collection where

the voice of childhood intersects with the spirit of jazz—as a form of rebellion, improvisation, and silent resistance against order and ready-made meaning.

The Gates

At the first gate, he said:

There is no god behind it.

At the second gate, he said:

But there is a boy behind it.

At the third gate, he said:

But there is a beast behind it.

At the fourth gate, he said:

There is nothing behind it. Nothing.

He wanted to open it.

But it did not allow him to.

1. Childhood as a Primary Voice Outside the System:

In this poem, the child is not portrayed as a fixed character with defined traits, but rather as a primary voice, present through gaze questioning, and declaration—without a clearly established identity. He stands before four gates, each representing a symbolic threshold leading to disappointment or meaninglessness, reflecting a sharp childlike thought that resists conformity (Bachelard, 1957, p. 211). At the first gate, the reader is confronted with the startling statement: “Il n’y a pas Dieu derrière” (“There is no God behind it”)—a shocking denial of the sacred marking one of the earliest moments of intellectual rebellion, where faith is replaced by doubt, and certainty by emptiness, akin to the existential experience expressed by Camus (Camus, 1942, p. 118).

The lines “Mais un garçon est derrière” / “Mais une bête est derrière” reveal the child’s perceptual fluidity: behind the doors lies either “the boy” (the familiar) or “the beast” (the nightmarish). This ambiguity represents a cognitive and perceptual shift, similar to what jazz music enacts when it disrupts harmonic expectations, creating space for reflection and emotional depth (Hall, 1992, p. 230).

2. Jazz as a Sonic Technique of Rebellion:

The structure of the poem is built on repetition and gradual displacement, visible

in the sequence of phrases : "À la première porte..." / "À la deuxième porte..." / "À la troisième...". This pattern resembles an improvised jazz riff, where a musical line is repeated with a shift in tone and rhythm each time, creating a crescendo of unresolved tension that conveys a constant search for meaning or liberation (Fadl, 1998, p. 32).

The repetition leads not to resolution, but to tension, culminating in the final gate's refusal to open: "Elle ne se laissa pas faire" ("It did not allow him to"). This negative act reflects not only an external impasse but also an internal resistance to closure, much like jazz, which resists structural regularity and seeks an individual, nonconformist voice (Kristeva, 1980, p. 70).

In this context, jazz is evoked not only as a cultural symbol, but also as a poetic technique of structural rebellion, operating through an improvisational logic that breaks traditional systems and invents a new voice rooted in marginality and difference.

3. The Poetic Self Between Formation and Explosion

In this poem, the self does not appear as a complete or final entity, but rather as a work in progress, developing through fragmented experiences that lack closure. Each gate represents an experience; each answer leads to disappointment, forming a structure that mirrors the very process of childhood:

Questions that do not lead to final answers

First disillusionments with the sacred or with knowledge

Experiences that end in stumbling, not completion

In the end, the self stands before a door that won't open—just like a jazz musician confronting an unresolved melody, yet continuing to play, reflecting the spirit of jazz and rebellion (Kristeva, 1980, p. 72).

4. Philosophical and Theoretical Background

Dib draws from the symbolism of thresholds, as analyzed by Gaston Bachelard in *Poétique de l'espace*, where doors are spaces of tension between inside and outside, self and world—metaphysical zones

reflecting the transformation of being from one state to another (Bachelard, 1957, p. 211).

The structural repetition in the poem echoes what Julia Kristeva calls "tonal intertextuality," where rhythmic recurrence fuses with language to generate layers of sensory and musical meaning (Kristeva, 1980, p. 68).

Childhood, in this context, is not merely a temporal stage, but a philosophical worldview, representing what Souriau described as an "inner atemporality"—a space where desire collides with interpretation, and silence meets expression (Souriau, 1956, p. 41).

Thus, the poem becomes a purely internal experience, where innocence and rebellion intersect, and the poetic self questions major symbols such as the human, the sacred, and the void. In this framework, jazz is not simply evoked as a musical reference, but as a mode of thought and being, rooted in hybridity, resistance, and the reinterpretation of the world through alternative language and transcendent poetic awareness.

5. CONCLUSION

In *L'Enfant-Jazz*, Mohammed Dib engages in a bold poetic experiment that blends sound and word, personal experience and collective history, longing and estrangement. This article has shown through four interwoven axes, that jazz is not merely a musical backdrop or cultural reference—it is a poetic and philosophical essence, infiltrating the expressive structure, the poetic identity, and the inner rhythm of the text.

In the first section, we saw how Dib interacts with jazz as a historical and cultural reference, linked to the struggles of Black communities and the logic of resistance—evoking this music as a memory of conflict, but also as a force of creation and rebirth.

The second section explored jazz as a symbol of hybridity and cosmopolitan belonging, transforming into an alternative language of affiliation—one that rejects

national and cultural boundaries and embraces exile as a space of creativity.

In the third section, focus was placed on the stylistic and musical dimension, showing how Dib draws from jazz's internal logic to disrupt grammatical structures and create a sonic poem that moves beyond fixed meaning toward affective resonance, mirroring jazz improvisation as a poetic strategy.

Finally, the fourth section read jazz as a representation of the poetic self, suspended between childhood and rebellion, between innocence and outcry—in an existential mode where identity becomes a moment of performance, not of definition.

L'Enfant-Jazz is not merely a celebration of poetry or music; it is a poetic model for how art can become a space of aesthetic and cultural resistance, a way to reimagine the self in a postcolonial world where language exile, and voice become existential stakes.

A central question remains open:

Can poetry play like a saxophone?

Can the word, in a world of exile and wandering, become a "note of resistance"?

L'Enfant-Jazz answers: Yes.

When writing becomes an act of freedom.

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